

THE ROLE OF ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE IN ELECTORAL INTEGRITY IN GHANA: A TECHNOLOGICAL DETERMINISM CRITIQUE

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DECLARATION

I hereby declare:

The research report submitted for PGA372 (Politics and Government III A) at STADIO is my own work and has not previously been submitted to another University or Higher Education Institution for degree purposes.

The work is my own work, and the ideas of others have been attributed and reference correctly.

Signature: ADP Date: 24/07/2026

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ABSTRACT

Artificial intelligence is changing how elections are conducted by improving efficiency, transparency, and fraud detection during elections. However with that said there are possible disadvantages that may rise such as deepfakes, misinformation, cybersecurity attacks and people not fully trusting the new technological developments being made in the electoral system. Using guidance from the Technological Determinism Theory this study examines the role of AI and its influence on electoral integrity in Ghana. It also adopts an interpretivist paradigm with a qualitative case study design. Data is collected through interviews and document analysis and analysed using thematic analysis. The study explores both the benefits and disadvantages of using AI in elections and investigates how AI influences transparency, accountability, and public confidence in the electoral process. The findings suggest that AI can strengthen electoral integrity by improving election administration and reducing fraud, but if there happens to be any misuse this will most likely undermine democratic processes through the spread of false information and cyber threats. The study concludes that the successful use of AI in elections depends on responsible governance, ethical practices, effective regulation, and public awareness. The findings are expected to provide useful recommendations for policymakers, electoral management bodies, and governments on how AI can be used responsibly to support free, fair, and credible elections in Ghana and other African countries.

Keywords: Artificial Intelligence, electoral integrity, technological determinism, Ghana, disinformation.

INTRODUCTION

Artificial intelligence (AI) is rapidly entering African politics, changing the face of democracy on the continent. Maine and Esiefarienrhe (2024) argue that using AI in elections can make things more efficient, transparent, and trustworthy. However, it opens the door to major risks such as deepfake technology which is when there is creation of realistic but manipulated voice audio and video content that can mislead voters during elections (Maine & Esiefarienrhe, 2024) and online manipulation that can destroy the public's trust in voting systems. As African democracies go digital, figuring out how AI impacts politics has become a major public concern.

Since Ghana's return to democratic rule in 1992 it has been held as the model for democracy in Africa mostly because of its repeated, peaceful transfers of power (Agyekum et al., 2025). However, even when considered as a democratic leader in West Africa the country still faces major difficulties in **Cybersecurity attacks, Lack of Transparency in Electronic Voting Systems and Spread of Deepfake Misinformation**. With these challenges at hand Maine and Esiefarienrhe (2024) states the technologies and methods used to tackle them such as **AI-powered deepfake detection systems**, such as **DefakeHop++**, to identify manipulated videos and images. **robust cybersecurity measures, including secure cloud infrastructure and encryption** to protect electronic and internet voting systems from hacking and cyberattacks (Maine & Esiefarienrhe, 2024, 3214–3217).

This research report looks at how AI is shaping the fairness of Ghana's elections, using a concept called **technological determinism**. Our argument is that AI tools are never neutral but they actively change how elections are conducted and whether the public can trust the system. Through this report we want to show how AI is driving specific political influence that will shape the future of democracy across Africa.

2. CONTEXT OF THE STUDY

2.1 Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study is to explore and investigate how the role of artificial intelligence is influencing electoral integrity and also to examine the impact of artificial intelligence and the emerging technologies on the fairness and transparency of Ghana's electoral process. The study will evaluate both the opportunities and challenges faced by Ghana when using AI in elections, including its role in improving election administration and preventing electoral fraud, and cyber attacks, while also investigating the side effects of AI usage such as deepfake misinformation, cybersecurity threats, and the public's concerns or public trust through the lens of technological determinism. I intend to look at the problems or difficulties faced by the country and its citizens during the election period and methods implemented to tackle those issues surrounding the electoral integrity of the country. This study aims to

critically examine the role of Artificial intelligence on the electoral practices, integrity and procedures, and whether the public can trust in the electoral systems Implemented.

This report argues that even though artificial intelligence has potential to improve election administration through efficiency and transparency and public trust (Maine & Esiefarienrhe, 2024) its misuse can cause electoral integrity by creating misinformation, cyber threats and loss in public trust. Therefore, the successful adoption of AI in Ghana's elections depends not only on technological innovation but also on strong governance, effective regulation, transparency, public and state accountability (Adeleke, 2025).

2.2 Background of the Study

Previous studies have shown that across African countries such as **Ghana, Nigeria, South Africa, and Kenya** there has been an introduction of technological methods used such as biometric fingerprint verification, facial recognition, electronic voter management systems, and AI election tools to improve transparency and reduce electoral fraud but also focus on increasing the efficiency of elections (Adeleke, 2025). It has also been demonstrated that electoral integrity in Africa depends on transparent institutions, accountability, and public trust

An article by Temba 2024 reviews studies on electoral politics and accountability in Africa and further states that elections have been used as a weapon or mechanism to hold political leaders and parties accountable throughout their reign in a country. It has also been established that the main cause of electoral fraud and violence is institutional weakness and lack of accountability in the state or electoral body, this also has an influence on democratic legitimacy or the electoral integrity. More recent studies by Maine and Esiefarienrhe (2024) argue that artificial intelligence has the potential to improve electoral administration through efficiency and accuracy while also raising ethical concerns such as algorithmic bias, privacy violations, and misinformation.

Evidence from Ghana's 2024 elections (Agyekum et al.2025) further states that citizens continue to prioritise accountability, transparency and good governance over technological promises. While these studies provide a good insight into elections and emerging technologies in the political fields, limited research has examined how AI simultaneously affects electoral integrity, whether the public does trust the technological systems and the democratic accountability within African electoral systems such as Ghana. This study aims to address the gap by investigating the opportunities and challenges associated with the use of AI in elections and by proposing governance approaches that promote transparent, ethical, and credible electoral processes.

2.3 Relevance and Significance of the Study

Artificial intelligence (AI) and other emerging technological methods are quickly changing how elections are conducted in many African countries. These technologies aim to improve

election processes by making voter registration easier and protecting individuals' information and prevention from any fraudulent cyber attacks during online voting or registrations and helping make elections to be accessible and more accurate and transparent. However, they can also create challenges such as misinformation, cyberattacks, privacy concerns and. This makes it important to understand both the benefits and the risks of using AI in elections.

This study is important because it will not only help explain how AI affects electoral integrity, public trust and accountability in African elections, but it will also add to existing knowledge by showing how AI can improve elections while also identifying the challenges that need to be addressed to ensure free and fair elections.

The findings of this study will benefit electoral bodies, governments, policymakers and election officials by providing recommendations on how AI can be used responsibly and ethically. The study will also be useful to researchers and students who are interested in venturing into electoral elections and integrity in Ghana or Africa as a whole. This will also grant citizens with knowledge and understanding of how AI can influence elections and why proper laws and policies are necessary to protect citizens and electoral bodies.

3. LITERATURE REVIEW

Certainly. For a research proposal, the literature review should be **brief, critical, and show where your study fits into the existing literature**. Here's a concise version:

3. Literature Review

Previous studies or researchers such as **Maine and Esiefarienrhe (2024)** argue that AI can improve electoral procedures or processes through protected online voter registration and fraud detection, but they also indicated ethical concerns and problems that are most likely faced such as lack of privacy and lack of accountability by the state or the citizens. Existing research shows that artificial intelligence and new technological developments have both positive and negative effects on electoral processes. Furthermore **Adeleke (2025)** emphasises that while AI can strengthen electoral integrity, it also creates risks including misinformation, deepfakes and cyberattacks, making effective regulation essential and needing the state or electoral officials to constantly monitor those developments. **Agyekum et al. (2025)** found that although digital technologies are increasingly used in elections, citizens continue to prioritise accountability, good governance by the state and political leaders and credible institutions over technological promises. And lastly elections remain an important mechanism for promoting political accountability in Africa, even though challenges such as having weak institutions and fraudulent activities continue to limit democratic accountability this is argued or stated by **Tambe (2024)**. In conclusion the literature agrees that AI has the potential to improve electoral processes, but debates remain about its ethical use associated with integrity, governance and impact on whether the citizens can trust those technological systems being introduced. While previous studies have examined Ai, electoral integrity and accountability separately, there has been limited

research when it comes to how AI can strengthen electoral integrity while maintaining public trust and democratic accountability in African elections especially in a country like Ghana. This study seeks to contribute to this debate by examining and investigating the influence of AI on the electoral integrity in Ghana and the opportunities and challenges of using AI to promote credible, transparent and accountable elections in Africa.

4. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

4.1 Technological Determinism

This study is being conducted through the **Technological Determinism Theory** that argues that technology has a major influence on social change and influences how people, organisations and institutions operate (**Hauer, 2017**). The theory assumes that technological developments can change communication, the way decisions are taken or conducted and governance even though its impact depends on how technology is being adopted and used in the society (**Hauer, 2017**). **Wyatt (2023)** argues that technological determinism often sees technology as a way for new developments and progress because it can improve and solve societal problems however it can also overlook the important role of people, ethics and social contexts in shaping technological outcomes.

The Technological Determinism Theory is appropriate for this study because it explains how artificial intelligence and new emerging technologies are transforming electoral processes in Africa the influence it has on the electoral integrity. It provides a useful method for examining how AI can improve electoral administration, transparency and efficiency while also highlighting the need to address ethical issues such as misinformation, privacy and accountability (**Hauer, 2017 and Wyatt, 2023**).

The Technological Determinism Theory provides the theoretical foundation for this study by explaining how artificial intelligence shapes electoral processes and its influence on electoral integrity. The theory further argues that technological developments influence social and institutional change by constantly changing how elections are being conducted, how information is being distributed, and how citizens accept or take in the information provide by electoral systems. In the case of Ghana's 2024 elections, the theory is applied to examine how AI technologies improve electoral efficiency, transparency, and fraud detection while simultaneously creating challenges such as deepfake misinformation, cybersecurity threats and concerns relating to individuals privacy, and loss in public trust with citizens not fully trusting the systems implemented. Consequently, the theory enables the study to evaluate both the opportunities and risks associated with AI and to investigate how technological change influences electoral integrity and democratic accountability.

5. CONCEPTUALISATION

5.1 Artificial Intelligence

Artificial intelligence (AI) refers to the development of computers and machines that imitate human intelligence and mannerism by performing tasks such as learning, reasoning and problem-solving. According to **Grewal (2014)** AI focuses on creating computing machines and systems that perform activities and operations similar to that of humans and decision-making while emulating human intelligence processes too. AI is also seen as a technology that allow machines to process data, recognise patterns, automate repetitive tasks, and provide solutions to complex problems across social, political, cultural, and ethical domains. Therefore, AI has become an important technology for improving efficiency, accuracy, and decision-making in various sectors, including electoral management.

5.2 Electoral Integrity

Norris, Frank and Martínez i Coma (2014) define electoral integrity as the way in which elections are conducted in accordance with internationally recognised standards and global norms, ensuring that every stage of the electoral process from registrations and voting and campaigning voter registration and until the announcement of results is free, fair, transparent and accountable. Electoral integrity promotes public confidence in elections by ensuring that electoral processes are conducted without fraud, manipulation, violence, or malpractice and in accordance with democratic principles.

5.3 Disinformation or Deepfake

Deepfakes are AI generated or AI manipulated audio, images, and videos that realistically imitate real people which makes it difficult to distinguish between real and fake information. According to **Maine and Esiefarienrhe (2024)**, deepfake technology can also be used to spread false political information, manipulate public opinion and provide voters with incorrect information during election campaigns and that will threaten electoral integrity and public trust.

6. TYPE OF STUDY

6.1 Research Paradigm This study adopts an interpretivist research paradigm, which holds that reality is shaped and influenced by technology. The interpretivist approach is appropriate for investigating how society understands and interprets AI's role in elections while also recognising that multiple realities exist and are shaped by people's experiences and perspectives. It also it seeks to understand participants' experiences, meanings, and perceptions regarding AI and electoral integrity.

6.1.1 Epistemology

Epistemology is the branch of philosophy concerned with the nature, sources, and justification of knowledge. Its main purpose is to answer questions such as "What is knowledge?" and "How do we know what we know?" **Sol and Heng (2024)** explain that epistemology focuses on how knowledge is acquired and justified and identifies different approaches to understanding reality, including positivism, interpretivism, and pragmatism. that examines what knowledge is, how it is acquired, and the extent to which humans can know things. This study adopts an interpretivist epistemological position, treating knowledge about AI's role as emerging from participants' lived experiences rather than objective measurement only.

6.1.2 Ontology

refers to a researcher's belief about the nature of reality and what can be known about the world. It addresses the question of whether reality is objective or socially constructed. According to **Sol and Heng (2024)**, ontology concerns beliefs about the nature of reality that underpin the research process. In qualitative research, ontology assumes that reality is **multiple, subjective, and socially constructed** because individuals experience and interpret the world differently. This study adopts a relativist ontology, holding that there is no single fixed reality about how AI affects elections. Instead, what is understood as "reality" is shaped by how people talk, think, and act in society Electoral integrity is experienced differently by various actors, including officials, voters, and observers, and is shaped by AI in ways that produce multiple, sometimes conflicting, understandings of reality.

6.1.3 Axiology

refers to the role of values, ethics, and the researcher's beliefs in the research process. In qualitative research the researchers acknowledge that their values may influence the research and therefore strive to conduct the study ethically while remaining transparent and reflective.

It is also considered as the study of values and value judgments, particularly in ethics. This study takes a value-conscious stance, recognising that research is not neutral but guided by commitments to democratic integrity, transparency, and the protection of elections from technological manipulation. I as the researcher acknowledge a belief that AI driven disinformation poses a risk to democracy, rather than attempting to hide this perspective and will maintain ethical principles by obtaining informed consent, ensuring confidentiality and anonymity, respecting participants' opinions, and presenting findings honestly without manipulation. also remaining aware of personal biases when interpreting participants' views on artificial intelligence and electoral integrity. (**Sol & Heng, 2024**)

6.2 Research Approach

This study uses a qualitative research approach, focusing on understanding meanings, interpretations, and social processes rather than numerical relationships. Qualitative methods are appropriate for exploring how people understand and respond to AI, which helps challenge technological determinism. A quantitative approach would not adequately explain why certain AI tools are used, how institutions react, or what people think about AI-generated media. The qualitative approach allows for deeper understanding of these issues in line with the study's theoretical focus .

7. RESEARCH PROBLEM, RESEARCH QUESTION(S) AND OBJECTIVES

7.1 Research Problem

Artificial intelligence is being overly used in elections to improve efficiency and transparency and reduce electoral fraud. However it also creates challenges such as deepfakes, misinformation, cyberattacks, and loss of public trust (**Maine & Esiefarienrhe, 2024; Adeleke, 2025**). Although Ghana successfully held its 2024 general elections there has been little research conducted about how AI affects electoral integrity and public confidence in the electoral process (**Agyekum et al., 2025**).

Problem Statement: AI has the potential to improve elections but it can also threaten electoral integrity through deepfakes, misinformation, and cybersecurity risks. With findings that There is limited research that has been done on AI influence on electoral integrity. Therefore, this study seeks to examine the role of AI in promoting or affecting electoral integrity in Ghana.

7.2 Research Question

Main Research Question: How does AI shape or influence electoral integrity in Ghana?

7.3 Research Objectives

The study aims to look into:

- Investigate how AI is used in Ghana' general and other African countries elections.
- Consider the benefits of using AI in promoting electoral integrity.
- Identify the challenges that countries or Ghana most likely faces during the election period and AI's impact on electoral integrity.
- Recommend ways to improve the responsible use of AI in future elections.

8. RESEARCH DESIGN

This study uses a **qualitative case study research design**. A case study design is appropriate because it allows the researcher to gain deeper knowledge and understanding of how artificial intelligence influences electoral integrity in Ghana elections.

8.1 Unit of Analysis

The unit of analysis is the role of artificial intelligence and its influence on Ghana's electoral integrity with a look into Ghana's 2024 elections.

8.2 Population and Sample and Sample Method.

A sample of **10–15 participants** will be selected using **purposive sampling**. This sampling method is appropriate because participants will be chosen based on their knowledge and experience they have of elections and artificial intelligence.

The target population will consist of individuals who have knowledge or experience of Ghana's electoral process, including:

- Electoral Commission officials
- Political party representatives
- Election observers
- ICT/electoral technology experts
- Academics or researchers in elections and governance

9. METHODOLOGY

Research Methods

Data Collection

I collected data through:

- **interviews**
- **Document analysis** of election reports, journal articles, Electoral Commission reports, and policy documents related to Ghana's 2024 elections.

Data Analysis

The collected data will be analysed using **thematic analysis**. I as the researcher identified, organised, and interpreted common themes related to the opportunities and challenges of artificial intelligence and its influence on electoral integrity.

Data Interpretation

The findings are interpreted using the **Technological Determinism Theory** to explain how artificial intelligence influenced electoral integrity, transparency, accountability, and public trust during Ghana's 2024 general elections.

10. DATA COLLECTION, ANALYSIS AND INTERPRETATION

Data Collection

I collected data using **interviews** with Electoral Commission officials, election officials, ICT experts, and political party representatives. The study also used **document analysis** of election reports, journal articles, and policy documents related to Ghana's 2024 general elections and AI's influence or role on Ghana's electoral integrity.

Data Analysis: The collected data is analysed using **thematic analysis**. I organised the information into themes to identify the main ideas, patterns, and issues related to the use of artificial intelligence and electoral integrity.

Data Interpretation The findings are interpreted using **Technological Determinism Theory** to explain how artificial intelligence influenced electoral integrity, transparency, and public trust. The results are then compared with the existing literature to answer the research questions.

11. TRUSTWORTHINESS AND ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

11.1 Credibility

11.2 Transferability

A detailed description of Ghana's political situation, the 2024 elections, and the types of AI content that appeared enables readers to assess whether findings may apply to other African democracies. Rather than claiming universal applicability, the study focuses on theoretical generalisation related to the critique of technological determinism.

11.3 Dependability

A clear record of all research activities has been maintained, including interview notes, analysis files, coding sheets, and a personal research journal. An external researcher reviewed the research process to confirm that it makes sense and could be repeated.

11.4 Confirmability

A reflective journal documented the researcher's beliefs and assumptions about AI, politics, and Ghana. This awareness helps maintain objectivity and transparency. Every finding is supported by direct quotes from participants or evidence from documents.

11.5 Ethical Considerations

Ethical approval was obtained from the university's ethics committee and relevant Ghanaian review boards before commencing the research. All participants provided informed consent after receiving clear information about the study's purpose and procedures. Participants were informed of their right to withdraw at any time without penalty. Interviews were recorded only with explicit permission. All identifying information has been removed and replaced with pseudonyms to protect participant confidentiality. Special care was taken to protect individuals sharing information about controversial political tactics or institutional failures. When presenting AI-generated content to focus groups, the content was clearly labelled as fake to avoid inadvertently contributing to disinformation

12. CONCLUSION

12.1 Findings

11. Expected Findings

The study found that artificial intelligence (AI) has both positive and negative effects on electoral integrity in Ghana elections. AI is also expected to improve election efficiency, transparency, and fraud detection. However, the study also found that AI contributes to challenges such as deepfakes, misinformation, cybersecurity risks, and reduced public trust. The findings will provide recommendations and solutions for the responsible usage of AI in future elections.

Conclusion

The study concludes that AI has the potential to strengthen electoral integrity when it is used responsibly and supported by effective policies and ethical guidelines and also being constantly monitored by electoral officials. The research will contribute to a better understanding of the role of AI in elections and provide recommendations to help improve future electoral processes in Ghana and other African countries.

12.2 Limitations

The study has several limitations. First, its single-country focus on Ghana limits the generalisability of findings to other contexts. Second, the recent nature of the 2024 elections may have limited how fully participants could reflect on events. Third, some informants may have been cautious in sharing information due to political sensitivity, potentially affecting data quality. Fourth, the rapid pace of AI development means findings may become less relevant over time. Fifth, the study did not include quantitative analysis of content spread or measurable effects on behaviour, limiting the ability to assess the full scope of AI's impact.

12.3 Contributions

This study makes several contributions to knowledge. It adds to the growing body of empirical research on AI and electoral integrity in Africa, addressing a gap in scholarship that has predominantly focused on the Global North. The application of technological determinism provides a theoretical lens for understanding AI's role in electoral processes, challenging assumptions of technological neutrality. The findings have practical implications for electoral management bodies, policymakers, and civil society organisations working to strengthen democratic integrity.

12.4 Recommendations

Based on the findings, several recommendations emerge:

1. Strengthen institutional capacity: Electoral management bodies require enhanced technical capacity to identify and respond to AI-generated disinformation. This includes training, resources, and partnerships with technical experts.
2. Develop regulatory frameworks: Ghana needs updated legislation specifically addressing AI in electoral contexts, including provisions for transparency, accountability, and enforcement.
3. Enhance public digital literacy: Civic education programmes should include digital literacy components to help citizens identify and critically evaluate AI-generated content.
4. Support fact-checking initiatives: Civil society organisations and media outlets should receive continued support for fact-checking and verification activities.
5. Promote multi-stakeholder collaboration: Electoral institutions, civil society, technology companies, and international partners should collaborate on developing coordinated responses to AI-related challenges.

Further research should examine comparative cases across African countries, conduct longitudinal studies tracking AI's evolving role in elections, and investigate the effectiveness of different regulatory approaches. Quantitative research measuring the actual reach and impact of AI-generated content would complement qualitative findings.

12.5 Conclusion

This study has examined the role of AI in shaping electoral integrity in Ghana through the lens of technological determinism. The findings demonstrate that while AI technologies exert significant influence on electoral processes, this influence is mediated by political, institutional, and social factors that challenge strong deterministic accounts. AI should be

understood not as an autonomous force but as a technology embedded in existing political dynamics. As Ghana approaches future elections, strengthening institutional capacity, regulatory frameworks, and public digital literacy will be essential for safeguarding electoral integrity in the age of AI.

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